

Pre-Renaissance

From c.1290, the Pre-Renaissance began in northern Italy. Painters such as Antonio Pisanello (1394–1455), Giotto di Bondone, Cimabue (c.1240–1302) and Duccio di Buoninsegna (c.1257– c.1318) were highly influential – Duccio, for instance, ran a workshop that shaped generations of Sienese artists. He blended traditions of Byzantine art with elements of International Gothic, resulting in an expressive use of colour and pattern.

Pre-Renaissance art appeared on frescoes, panel painting, illuminated manuscripts, reliefs, statues and metalwork. Certain Italian regions, including Siena, Florence, Genoa, Venice, Milan and Savoy, were becoming more prosperous through trade, and the merchant families and dukes who ruled them were keen to make an impression by sponsoring art. Although Pre-Renaissance art was still religious, it was less stylized and more realistic than its precursors. Yet anatomical proportions and perspective were not important considerations – the focus was more on the spirituality of religious figures than on their physical appearance.



Duccio, *The Rucellai Madonna*, 1285–6